

The key fox and the lantern festival treasure

Hidden treasure story • 11-12 years old



Chapter 1: The Empty Banner Pole

The morning of Willowbrook's Spring Lantern Festival was supposed to smell like cinnamon buns and fresh paint. Instead, it smelled like worry.

Lena Hart stood in the town square and stared at the tall banner pole. It was bare. No bright ribbon. No cheerful "WELCOME, SPRING!" flapping above the stalls. Just a lonely hook that squeaked in the wind like a question.

"You're frowning so hard your eyebrows might bump," said Amira, slipping beside her. Amira's braids were tied up with green thread, like tiny vines.

"I'm practicing," Lena muttered. "For when the festival gets canceled."

Sora, small and quick, hopped onto the edge of the fountain. "It won't. We'll fix it."

"How?" asked Chloe, who carried her sketchbook like it was a shield. She was almost twelve, like the rest of them, and she had a calm voice that made people listen—even when she was panicking on the inside.

Mr. Pindle, the festival organizer, shuffled past with a clipboard and a face that looked like it had been folded too many times. "Girls," he said, trying to sound cheerful and failing, "the lantern paper shipment got soaked in last night's storm. The musicians want paying. The baking contest needs prizes. And the town fund..." He lowered his voice. "The town fund is as empty as my cookie tin."

Amira gasped. "But the lantern parade is our thing!"

Lena's stomach tightened. The festival wasn't just fun. It was how everyone in Willowbrook felt like a team again after a long winter. It was how Mrs. Kline sold her honey. How the library raised money for new books. How the old folks' home

got visitors who didn't forget them.

Chloe flipped open her sketchbook and showed a pencil drawing of the square filled with glowing lanterns. "We can't let it disappear," she said.

Sora squinted at Mr. Pindle's clipboard. "How much do you need?"

Mr. Pindle hesitated, then sighed. "Two thousand dollars. By Friday."

"Friday?" Lena's voice squeaked. Today was Tuesday.

Amira crossed her arms. "We could wash cars."

"In a town where half the people own bicycles?" Sora said.

Chloe tapped her pencil against her teeth. "Unless we find... something."

Lena's eyes drifted to the old stone fountain. It had been there forever, carved with vines and tiny animals that looked like they were running in circles. On the lowest ring, half-hidden by moss, was a strange symbol: a fox with a key in its mouth.

Sora leaned over. "That wasn't there last year."

"It was," Lena said slowly. "But it was covered. The storm washed the moss off."

Chloe traced the fox with her finger. "A key fox... like a clue."

Amira grinned, the kind of grin that meant trouble and adventure had just become best friends. "My grandma tells stories about a treasure hidden in Willowbrook. A 'community treasure.' I thought it was just to make kids brush their teeth."

Lena's heart thumped faster. "What if it's real?"

Sora hopped down, eyes bright. “Then we find it. We save the festival.”

“And if it’s not real,” Chloe said, closing her sketchbook with a determined snap, “we’ll still have tried. Together.”

Lena looked at her three friends—Amira bold as a drumbeat, Sora sharp as a pin, Chloe steady as a lighthouse. The wind squeaked the empty hook again.

“Okay,” Lena said. “Let’s go treasure hunting.”

Chapter 2: The Fox and the Library Map

The Willowbrook Library smelled like paper, dust, and secrets. Mrs. Delaney, the librarian, wore glasses on a chain and could silence a room with one raised eyebrow.

The girls tiptoed to the local history section, trying to look like they were doing homework and not plotting an illegal adventure.

Sora whispered, “We need anything about... hidden money. Or hidden anything.”

Amira pulled a thick book from the shelf. “Legends of Willowbrook.” She opened it and immediately sneezed. “This book is older than my grandpa’s jokes.”

Chloe leaned in. “Read.”

Amira skimmed until her finger stopped. “‘The Key Fox marks the fountain ring. Follow where the fox would run at dawn, and you will find the first door.’” She blinked. “That is... extremely specific.”

Lena felt a fizzing excitement in her chest. “There’s more?”

Amira turned the page. ““The treasure is not for one pocket. It is for the town heart.’”

“That sounds like community treasure,” Chloe said softly.

Sora was already scanning the room. “Where’s the rest of the clue?”

Lena noticed a display case near the front, filled with old postcards and a faded map titled WILLOWBROOK: 1899. In the corner was the same fox-with-a-key symbol, tiny but unmistakable.

“Mrs. Delaney?” Lena called, forcing her voice into polite-mode. “Can we look at the map? For... a project?”

Mrs. Delaney’s eyes narrowed. “A project called ‘Mischief’?”

“A project called ‘Save the Festival,’” Chloe said honestly.

That made Mrs. Delaney pause. Her expression softened, just a little, like butter on warm toast. She opened the display case with a small key. “Maps are meant to be read,” she said. “Not worshipped behind glass. But be careful.”

The map crackled when Lena touched it. Roads looped like ribbons. The river was drawn with little fish. There were sketches of buildings that didn’t exist anymore.

Sora pointed. “The fountain is here. ‘Where the fox would run at dawn’—that means east. Because dawn.”

Amira nodded. “So we go east from the fountain.”

Chloe traced the line with her pencil. “East is... the old orchard hill. But there’s something marked here.” She squinted. “A tiny door symbol.”

Lena swallowed. “A door in a hill?”

Sora grinned. "A door is just a wall that decided to be helpful."

They rolled the map carefully. Mrs. Delaney watched them with a look that said she knew exactly what was happening and had decided not to stop it.

As they left, she called after them, "If you find anything that belongs to the town, you bring it back to the town. Understood?"

Lena glanced at her friends. "Understood."

Outside, the sky was a bright, rinsed blue after the storm. The kind of day that made you believe in hidden things.

Chapter 3: The Orchard Hill Door

Orchard Hill was a tangle of grass, apple trees, and the smell of damp earth. Most of the trees were old and crooked, as if they'd spent their lives leaning in to gossip.

The girls climbed the path, shoes slipping on wet leaves.

Amira panted. "If treasure hunters always have to hike, I want treasure that comes with a chairlift."

Sora pushed a low branch aside. "Treasure comes with sore legs. That's the rule."

At the top, Chloe stopped. "Look."

Half-buried in ivy was a small wooden door set into the hillside. It was round, like something from a fairy tale, but the iron handle looked real and rusty and serious.

Lena's pulse drummed in her ears. "So... we found the first door."

Sora crouched, inspecting the handle. "No lock."

Amira tried the handle. It didn't budge. "It's stuck."

Chloe ran her fingers along the edge. "Swollen from rain. We need leverage."

Lena spotted a fallen branch and wedged it carefully under the handle. "On three," she said.

"One," whispered Amira.

"Two," said Chloe.

"Three," said Sora.

They pulled together. The door groaned like an old man standing up, then cracked open with a sigh of cool air.

Inside was darkness and the smell of apples—sharp and sweet. Lena peered in. "Do we have a flashlight?"

Sora proudly held up a small torch from her pocket. "I come prepared for mysterious holes in hills."

Amira snorted. "Normal twelve-year-old stuff."

They stepped into a narrow passage lined with smooth stones. Water dripped somewhere deeper in. Their footsteps sounded too loud, like the tunnel was listening.

The passage ended at a tiny room. On the wall hung a metal box with a crank and a slot for paper. Above it was a carved message:

THE TOWN HEART BEATS IN MANY HANDS.

TURN TOGETHER.

Chloe frowned. "A crank."

Sora grabbed it. "We turn it."

Lena caught her wrist. "Together. It says so."

Amira placed her hand on the crank too. Chloe added hers. Lena joined last, feeling the warmth of her friends' fingers.

"Ready?" Lena asked.

"Ready," they whispered, like a pact.

They turned. At first it was stiff, then it moved, grinding like gears waking up. The wall shivered.

A hidden panel slid open with a click, revealing a narrow drawer. Inside was a rolled piece of thick paper and a small bronze token stamped with—of course—a fox holding a key.

Amira lifted the paper carefully. "Please be a clue and not a bill."

Sora unrolled it under the flashlight beam. It was a riddle written in neat, old-fashioned handwriting:

WHEN MUSIC HIDES AND RAINBOWS REST,

FIND THE PLACE WHERE STORIES NEST.

BENEATH THE STAIR THAT SPIRALS DOWN,

THE SECOND KEY IS WAITING, BROWN.

Chloe's eyes widened. "Where stories nest... the library."

"And 'music hides' could mean the old band room?" Amira guessed.

Lena's brain clicked. "No—'When music hides'... the old theater! It's closed. And it has rainbow curtains."

Sora snapped her fingers. "The Willowbrook Playhouse. It's been shut for years."

Chloe tucked the riddle into her sketchbook. "Then that's our next stop."

As they backed out of the hill, Lena glanced at the token in Amira's hand. It felt heavier than a coin. Like a promise.

"Two thousand dollars," Lena murmured.

Amira bumped her shoulder. "Or a treasure chest. Or a dragon. Don't limit your dreams."

"I'm limiting my dragons," Sora said. "But I'll accept a small, polite one."

They laughed, and the sound rolled down Orchard Hill like a bright marble.

Chapter 4: The Sleeping Playhouse

The Willowbrook Playhouse sat at the end of Maple Street, its paint peeling like sunburn. A sign hung crooked: CLOSED FOR REPAIRS. The windows were dusty, and the front doors were chained.

Chloe studied the building. "How do we get in without... you know... becoming criminals?"

Sora lifted her chin. “We use brains. Not bolt cutters.”

Amira pointed to the side. “There’s a window open. Up there.”

Lena followed her finger. It was high, but a drainpipe ran beside it.

Sora rubbed her hands. “Climbing. Excellent. My favorite way to regret choices.”

They took turns. Sora went first, nimble as a squirrel, then Chloe, careful and steady. Amira climbed with dramatic grunts, as if narrating her own heroic movie. Lena went last, heart racing, palms sweaty, but she kept going.

Inside, the playhouse was dim and smelled of velvet and old popcorn. Seats sat in rows like sleepy teeth. The stage curtain—faded but still rainbow-striped—hung in heavy folds.

“Rainbows rest,” Chloe whispered.

Sora shone her torch around. “Riddle says ‘beneath the stair that spirals down.’ Where’s a spiral stair?”

They found it near the backstage door: a narrow metal staircase curling into the basement like a corkscrew.

Amira peered down. “That is a staircase designed by someone who hates ankles.”

Lena started down first, gripping the railing. The metal was cold. Each step creaked like it had something to complain about.

In the basement, crates were stacked in towers. Old costumes hung like ghosts in plastic covers. A broken tuba lay in the corner, looking embarrassed.

“Music hides,” Sora said, pointing to a shelf of instruments covered with sheets.

They searched beneath the spiral stair. Chloe crouched and brushed away dust. “Here—something brown.”

It was a small leather pouch, tied with twine. Sora untied it and tipped it gently into her palm. Out slid a second fox token—darker, like aged copper—and a folded note.

Lena held her breath as Chloe read aloud:

TWO KEYS OPEN WHAT ONE CANNOT.

TO FIND THE THIRD, SEEK WATER’S SPOT.

WHERE LANTERNS FLOAT AND WISHES SAIL,

THE BRIDGE WILL TELL THE REST OF THE TALE.

Amira’s eyes lit up. “Lanterns float... that’s the river! During the festival we float little candle boats.”

Lena imagined the river at night, dotted with tiny lights. For a second it hurt, thinking of it not happening.

Chloe folded the note carefully. “The bridge. Which bridge?”

Sora said, “Old Stone Bridge. It’s the only one that looks like it has secrets.”

A thump sounded above them.

They froze.

Another thump—followed by a long, slow scrape.

Amira whispered, “Please tell me that’s a friendly ghost.”

Sora clicked off her torch, plunging them into darkness. “Shh.”

Footsteps moved across the stage overhead. Someone was inside the playhouse.

Lena’s mind raced. They couldn’t get caught. Not when they were this close.

Chloe whispered, “Back to the stairs. Quiet.”

They crept up, one step at a time. The basement felt suddenly too small, like it was holding its breath with them.

At the top, Sora peeked through a crack in the backstage door. A tall figure stood in the aisle, sweeping a flashlight beam over the seats.

“Who is that?” Lena mouthed.

The figure muttered, “Kids always poking around. Not this time.”

Amira’s eyes widened. “That’s Mr. Griggs. He owns half the buildings in town. Including this one.”

Mr. Griggs moved toward the side hallway—toward their open window.

Sora whispered, “If he locks it, we’re stuck.”

Lena’s courage felt shaky, like jelly, but she forced it to stand up. “We need a distraction.”

Chloe’s gaze flicked to the stage. A rope hung from the fly system, tied to the rainbow curtain.

Chloe whispered, “Curtain.”

Amira’s grin returned, delighted and terrified. “Oh yes.”

Chloe tugged the rope hard. The rainbow curtain whooshed open with a dramatic roar, like a giant clearing its throat.

Mr. Griggs yelped. “What in—?”

While he hurried toward the stage, the girls slipped through the hallway and climbed out the window one by one, dropping into the bushes with muffled thuds.

They ran, breathless and giggling, until the playhouse disappeared behind trees.

Sora gasped, “We just... used theater to escape.”

Amira bowed while running. “Art saves lives.”

Lena clutched the two tokens in her pocket. They clinked together like tiny bells.

“The bridge,” she said. “Now.”

Chapter 5: The Bridge That Spoke in Shadows

Old Stone Bridge arched over the Willowbrook River like the back of a sleeping dinosaur. The water below was swollen from the storm, churning brown and loud.

The girls walked onto the bridge as the late afternoon sun slid toward the treetops. Long shadows stretched between the stones.

Chloe ran her hand along the railing. “Where would a clue be hidden?”

Sora crouched and inspected the stones like a detective on a TV show Lena wasn’t allowed to watch. “Look for the fox symbol.”

Amira leaned over the side. “If I fall in, tell my grandma I died doing something

stylish.”

“You’re wearing mismatched socks,” Sora said. “Very stylish.”

They searched until Lena spotted something carved into a stone near the center: a fox with a key, smaller than her palm.

“Here,” she said.

Below the carving was a narrow slot, like a coin slot, but wider.

Chloe held up the two tokens. “Two keys open what one cannot.”

Lena’s hands trembled as she took the tokens. She slid them into the slot side by side. They fit perfectly, like they belonged there.

For a moment nothing happened. Then the stone clicked.

A section of the railing shifted, revealing a hidden metal box tucked inside the bridge. Sora pulled it out with a triumphant huff.

“Please be treasure,” Amira whispered. “Or at least directions to treasure.”

Inside the box was a third token—silver this time—and a small glass vial containing a rolled strip of paper so tiny it looked like a fortune-cookie message for ants.

Chloe carefully unrolled it with the tip of her pencil:

THIRD KEY SHINES WHERE CLOCKS FORGET.

BENEATH THE FACE THAT NEVER WET.

WHEN FOUR STAND CLOSE AND SPEAK ONE NAME,

THE FINAL DOOR WILL SHOW ITS FRAME.

“Clock?” Lena said. “We have a clock tower.”

Sora nodded. “The old one by Town Hall. It stopped years ago.”

Amira frowned. “Beneath the face that never wet... under the clock face. It’s covered. It doesn’t get rained on.”

Chloe looked at the river, then at Lena. “And ‘four stand close.’ That’s us.”

A splash sounded below. They jerked around.

On the riverbank, half-hidden by reeds, stood Mr. Griggs. He was looking up at the bridge, his eyes sharp as nails.

Lena’s mouth went dry. “He followed us.”

Amira hissed, “How does he walk so quietly? He’s shaped like a filing cabinet.”

Mr. Griggs called, “I know you’ve got something. Hand it over and I won’t call your parents.”

Sora muttered, “He doesn’t even know which parents. We have four.”

Chloe’s face tightened. “Why does he want it?”

Lena thought of the festival, the empty banner pole, the town fund. “Maybe he wants the treasure for himself.”

Mr. Griggs started up the path to the bridge entrance.

Sora grabbed Lena’s sleeve. “Run.”

They sprinted off the bridge and into the riverside park, ducking behind trees

and benches. Lena's lungs burned, but she kept going, focusing on one thing: Friday. Lanterns. Community.

They reached a cluster of bushes near the duck pond and crouched, panting.

Amira whispered, "We can't lead him to the clock tower."

Chloe's eyes narrowed, thinking fast. "Then we don't."

Sora grinned. "We split up?"

Lena shook her head. "No. Together."

Chloe pointed toward the market street, busy with people setting up early festival stalls. "We lose him in the crowd. Then go to the clock tower from the back alley."

Amira nodded. "Operation: Be Normal Children Who Are Definitely Not Carrying Ancient Treasure Tokens."

They popped up and walked briskly—very normal, very casual, very sweaty—toward the market street. Lena glanced back once. Mr. Griggs stood at the park entrance, scanning.

Then Mrs. Kline waved from her honey stall. "Girls! Want a taste?"

Amira didn't miss a beat. "Yes please! We are simply children enjoying honey and not fleeing a villain."

Mrs. Kline blinked. "What?"

"Nothing!" Amira said, stuffing a honey spoon into her mouth.

Sora whispered, "You're going to get us all grounded."

Chloe whispered back, “Keep walking.”

They moved with the crowd, turning when needed, blending into laughter and shopping bags and the clatter of tent poles. At last, the clock tower rose ahead, stone and silent, its frozen hands pointing to 3:17 forever.

Lena touched the silver token in her pocket. “Almost there,” she breathed.

Chapter 6: The Name in the Clock Tower

The clock tower stood behind Town Hall like a forgotten guard. A side door was unlocked—because Willowbrook was the kind of town that still believed most people were decent.

Inside, the air was cool and smelled of stone dust. A narrow staircase spiraled upward.

Amira peered up. “More stairs. Treasure really hates elevators.”

They climbed, footsteps echoing. At the top, they reached a platform behind the clock face. Light filtered through the glass, making pale squares on the floor.

“Beneath the face that never wet,” Chloe whispered.

Sora searched along the base of the wall. “There has to be a mechanism.”

Lena spotted a small indentation in the stone floor—four shallow shapes, like footprints in a line.

“Four stand close,” Lena said.

They stepped onto the shapes, shoulders nearly touching in the tight space. Lena could feel Chloe’s steady breathing, Amira’s restless energy, Sora’s

impatience like a humming engine.

The last line tugged at Lena's mind: "Speak one name."

"What name?" Amira whispered. "The town? Willowbrook?"

Chloe looked thoughtful. "Or someone who started the treasure."

Sora shone her torch on the wooden beams. Carved into one beam were initials: E.P.

Lena remembered Mr. Pindle's tired face. Then she remembered the book: "The treasure is for the town heart." This wasn't about one person being rich. It was about everyone.

"The name," Lena said slowly, "is 'Willowbrook.'"

They all looked at each other.

"Together," Chloe said.

They leaned in, like four conspirators in a secret club, and spoke in one voice, clear and firm:

"Willowbrook."

For a second, nothing.

Then a deep click echoed through the tower. The stone beneath their feet trembled. A section of the wall slid aside, revealing a narrow doorway framed in iron.

Amira squealed softly. "Final door!"

Sora's eyes gleamed. "Open it before it changes its mind."

Inside was a small chamber, surprisingly clean. In the center sat a wooden chest with metal corners. It looked heavy and real and exactly like what Lena had pictured when she first said the word treasure.

Chloe approached carefully. "Is it trapped?"

Amira held up the tokens. "We have three keys. It's basically asking to be opened."

On the chest lid were three fox-shaped keyholes.

Lena handed the tokens over. Her fingers tingled as each one slid into place: bronze, copper, silver. Chloe turned them gently.

The chest clicked and opened with a sigh.

Inside were neatly stacked envelopes, a small leather-bound ledger, and a folded cloth embroidered with tiny lanterns. On top lay a note written in the same neat hand:

FOR THE FESTIVAL.

FOR THE LIBRARY.

FOR THE SQUARE WHERE ALL MEET.

SPEND IT WITH CARE.

REMEMBER: TREASURE GROWS WHEN SHARED.

Amira lifted an envelope and peeked inside. Her eyes went huge. "It's money. Real money."

Sora did a silent victory dance that involved a lot of elbows.

Chloe opened the ledger. "It's a fund. People added to it over years. It's meant for... exactly this."

Lena's throat tightened. She pictured the empty banner pole again, but this time she imagined it filled with color.

"We can save it," she whispered.

A sound came from the staircase—heavy steps, climbing fast.

Sora snapped her head up. "He found us."

Mr. Griggs's voice echoed upward. "I know you're in there!"

Amira clutched the embroidered cloth like it was a flag. "We can't let him take it."

Chloe shut the chest. "We don't have to fight. We have something stronger."

Lena understood. She grabbed the note and one envelope, then shoved the chest back into the chamber and slid the wall panel closed. The doorway vanished, stone becoming plain again.

The footsteps reached the platform. Mr. Griggs appeared, breathing hard, his flashlight beam jittering.

"There you are," he said sharply. "What did you take?"

Lena stepped forward, heart pounding, but her voice steady. "This treasure belongs to Willowbrook. Not to you. Not to us."

Mr. Griggs's eyes narrowed. "Prove it."

Chloe held up the note. "It says so."

Sora added, “Also, four twelve-year-olds just opened your clock tower like a puzzle box, so maybe don’t argue.”

Amira waved the envelope. “We’re taking this to Mr. Pindle and Mrs. Delaney. Right now. In public. With witnesses.”

Mr. Griggs’s jaw worked like he was chewing invisible gum. The market noise drifted in from below—voices, laughter, the clink of metal poles. Real life. Real people.

He glanced toward the stairs, as if considering grabbing it and running. But even he seemed to realize how that would look: a grown man stealing from kids to cancel a festival.

He lowered his flashlight. “Fine,” he muttered. “But this doesn’t end here.”

Sora shrugged. “It ends at the festival. With snacks.”

They walked past him, close together, shoulders brushing, and descended the stairs without running. Lena’s knees felt wobbly, but she kept her chin up.

Community treasure, she thought. Community courage, too.

Chapter 7: Lanterns Like Captured Stars

By Friday evening, the town square had transformed.

New lantern paper arrived—paid for. Musicians tuned their instruments. Stalls overflowed with honey jars, painted stones, cinnamon buns, and handmade bracelets. A fresh banner danced above it all: WELCOME, SPRING!—painted by Chloe, with a tiny fox holding a key in the corner.

Mr. Pindle stood beside the fountain, eyes shiny. “I don’t know how you did it,”

he said, voice thick. "But you saved us."

Lena glanced at her friends. They had told the truth to the town council, shown the note, and handed over the envelopes. Mrs. Delaney had smiled in a way that felt like a medal. Even Mr. Griggs had been forced to back off, surrounded by too many watchful neighbors.

Amira nudged Lena. "Admit it. You were born to be dramatic."

"I was born to eat cinnamon buns," Lena said, taking a bite. "The hero stuff is extra."

Sora held up a small lantern boat—paper folded neatly, a tiny candle inside. "Ready for the wishing float?"

Chloe's lantern was decorated with drawn apple trees and a round little door in a hill. "For remembering," she said.

They walked to the riverbank with the crowd. The water had calmed, reflecting the sunset like molten gold.

People knelt and set lantern boats on the surface. One by one, they drifted away, carrying flickering wishes downstream.

Lena set hers down carefully. On it she had written, in careful marker: FOR WILLOWBROOK.

Amira whispered, "What did you wish?"

Lena smiled. "That we always show up for each other."

Sora snorted softly. "I wished for a lifetime supply of snacks."

Chloe said, "Both can be true."

They watched the boats float, the lights bobbing like captured stars. Music rose from the square, warm and lively. Laughter carried across the water.

Lena felt something settle inside her—not just relief, but a quiet strength. They hadn't been the only ones to save the festival. The treasure had helped, yes, but so had everyone who painted signs, baked buns, strung lights, and showed up with their hands and time.

She turned to her friends. "We should take a picture," she said.

Amira patted her pockets. "My phone is dead."

Sora checked hers. "Mine is at one percent, which is basically a goodbye letter."

Chloe closed her sketchbook and looked at the river. "Then we take it the old way."

Lena followed her gaze. The lanterns drifted, glowing softly. The banner fluttered. The fountain fox symbol caught the light. Her friends stood beside her, faces warm in the candle-glow—four girls pressed close, like they had been on the clock tower stones, speaking one name.

Lena held the moment in her mind as carefully as a lantern boat on water.

A photo you couldn't lose.

A treasure you didn't have to hide.

The quiz: did you understand the story well?

1) What exact symbol helped the girls find the first clue at the fountain?

- A fox holding a key carved on the fountain ring
- A small lantern carved into the stone
- An apple with a tiny door drawn beneath it
- A carved musical note near the water spout

2) Which three colors or metals describe the three tokens the girls collected?

- Bronze, copper, and silver
- Gold, bronze, and iron
- Copper, brass, and gold
- Silver, iron, and bronze

3) How did the girls open the final hidden doorway in the clock tower?

- They stood on four floor marks and said the name 'Willowbrook' together
- They used the three tokens to unlock a panel and pushed a lever
- They pulled the rainbow curtain from the playhouse to reveal a switch
- They placed the lanterns on the floor and waited for the clock to move

4) Which location did not contain one of the clues or tokens?

- The bakery where cinnamon buns were sold
- The orchard hill with the round wooden door
- The Willowbrook Playhouse under the spiral stair
- Old Stone Bridge with a hidden box in the railing

5) Why did Mr. Griggs try to follow and confront the girls during their search?

- He wanted the treasure for himself and to stop them from taking it
- He was hired by the town council to help find the treasure
- He was looking for lost tools he had left in the playhouse
- He wanted to protect the girls and guide them to the clock tower

6) What was the main intended purpose of the treasure according to the note inside the chest?

- To support the festival, the library, and the town square where people meet
- To buy personal inventions for a single family in Willowbrook
- To be hidden again and kept secret by the town leaders
- To be given as prizes only for the best musical performers

Correct answers:

1) A fox holding a key carved on the fountain ring 2) Bronze, copper, and silver 3) They stood on four floor marks and said the name 'Willowbrook' together 4) The bakery where cinnamon buns were sold 5) He wanted the treasure for himself and to stop them from taking it 6) To support the festival, the library, and the town square where people meet

Glossary: complicated words in the story

Clipboard: A flat board with a clip to hold papers while you write.

Shipment: A group of goods sent together to a place, like by truck or boat.

Moss: A soft, green plant that grows on stones or wet ground.

Symbol: A picture or mark that stands for an idea or thing.

Crackled: Made a series of small sharp sounds, like dry paper or fire.

Groaned: Made a low sound showing effort, pain, or that something moved slowly.

Riddle: A short puzzle or question made to be solved or guessed.

Crank: A handle you turn to make a machine or box work.

Token: A small object used as a sign, a key, or a special coin.

Chamber: A small room or enclosed space inside a building.